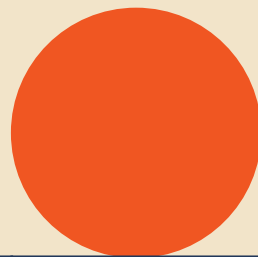
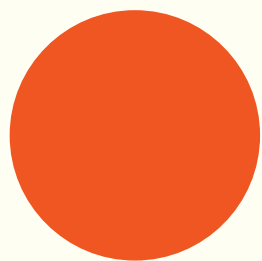


Leading a Team



What Makes You a Leader?

It's not your age. It's not your gender identity or country of origin or marital status or any other box you might tick on a census form. It's not the name of the university on your diploma—or, for that matter, whether you have a diploma at all. Leading a team is about intangibles; it begins with a deep understanding of yourself and an ability to connect with others. Sure, these traits might come easier to some individuals than others. But soft skills are still, well, skills. That means they can be practiced, built upon, improved. Doing so requires the right mix of expert advice, philosophical consideration, and practical tips. This guide contains all three, plus some fresh ideas and a few unexpected learning opportunities. Ready to dive in? Let's get to work.



MICRO LESSON: TERMINOLOGY

Don't fall into the common trap of using the terms *management* and *leadership* interchangeably. **Management** involves setting and executing the goals and strategy of an organization, and coordinating the efforts of workers to meet objectives. **Leadership**, meanwhile, is the ability to guide others (and maximize their potential) to achieve certain goals—both shared and personal—through social influence.

Defining Core Values

Take stock of your organization's mission statement, then use this three-step method to establish a code of conduct that applies to both your work and personal life



Start by **working backward from your noes**. Establishing boundaries is a necessary first step in structuring a framework for how your team will navigate everything, from your weekly schedule to conflict resolution.



Next, **write down your yeses**. Does your team value timeliness? Empathy? What about being factually correct? By identifying the qualities and virtues that compel your team most in everyday life, you can hone in on the things you do naturally well.



Finally, stop for a moment and **consider the gray areas**. Are there value areas about which you feel unsure? Make sure that you're clear on how your noes and yeses will be applied—and that you frame the subsequent messaging to your team in a way that's unambiguous.

EXERCISE:

ASK YOURSELF THIS

> Do my values motivate, uplift, and empower my team?

> How can I define and establish these values while ensuring each aligns with my organization’s mission?

> What limitations does my team have? What are my own limitations? How can I honor both to cultivate a culture of accountability and respect?

TRY THIS

Map out three values you want to instill in your team, then brainstorm examples of actions that you can take in order to demonstrate those values:

Value 1

Value 2

Value 3

Action(s)

Action(s)

Action(s)



**“Everyone is valuable.
Everyone is necessary.
If my team isn’t feeling
that, then there’s
something wrong with
the way I’m leading.”**

— SHONDA RHIMES

CASE STUDY

Leading by Example

When a pro racing driver became aware of how his presence affected his team, he decided to make an intentional change

Lewis Hamilton is widely considered the greatest driver in Formula 1 auto racing history. The sport is a testing ground for cutting-edge transportation technology, and the division of labor on the teams reflects this complexity; there isn't one mechanic for the engine and one for the aerodynamics, but rather a multiperson crew for each.

As the driver, Lewis is often a fulcrum point, gathering key intel and collaborating with various parties to ensure he's prepared on race day. Learning to leverage this role has been crucial to his success.

"I noticed the effect that I was having on my crew and myself," he explains. "Whether I bring good or positive or bad energy into the garage, I noticed it having a ripple effect in terms of our performance or how engaging or how motivated people were around me."

The takeaway? Holding people to high standards is only possible when those you lead feel like you've set the example for those standards. Being in the trenches and fostering relationships built on trust goes a long way toward creating a dependable and enduring—and winning—squad.

EXERCISE: ASK YOURSELF THIS

- > How can I show up for my team in a fresh way this week?
- > When team morale feels low, what specific actions can I take to uplift my teammates?
- > Am I sharing credit when my team achieves success? And am I sharing responsibility when we underperform and/or things don't go as planned?



Blending Complementary Skills

Being a leader doesn't mean you have to (or should) go it alone

Right now, you might be in the throes of launching a marketing campaign, designing a new product, or trying to exceed your key performance indicators (KPIs). How can you maximize your chances of success? It's not enough to simply hire good people; you must create an environment that encourages the empowerment of each member of the team. For award-winning television showrunner Shonda Rhimes, that means sharing the spotlight. "Leadership is about making sure that you are not working in a hero model where everything depends on you," she says.

As a leader, you need to rely on other people to help you support the wider team and reach your goals. And that means finding individuals with diverse skill sets and perspectives that are different from yet complementary to your own. According to former U.S. president Bill Clinton: "There are literally mountains of research that show diverse teams make better decisions than homogeneous teams or lone geniuses."

Think about it: One lone genius in a luxury setting, trying to resolve an issue solo, pales in comparison to 99 distinctly different individuals in meager conditions, channeling their brain power to do the same. For an

organization to thrive in the modern era, it must reflect the community at large, representing a variety of opinions, backgrounds, ages, and cultures.

"When you're building a team, it's important to know where your own weaknesses are—and what strengths you need to compliment those weaknesses."

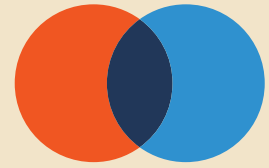
— ANNA WINTOUR

MICRO LESSON: COMMUNICATION

- > **Blame is the language of double regression.** It causes your team to be frustrated and shut down, and, in turn, prevents progress. Avoid it at all costs.
- > **Balance tough talk and compassion.** Build the rapport necessary with each team member so it's clear that you're not the enemy. You're there to support and encourage growth as a unit.
- > **Create a safe space.** Equity at work begins with leaders listening, then advocating for necessary adjustments and improvements. Embrace the differences in your staff and empower them to speak up.

Dynamic Duos

History shows us that two heads are better than one



Technical expert **Orville Wright** and his brother **Wilbur Wright**, who managed the business side of their aviation startup.



Apple Computer's visionary strategist **Steve Jobs** and its pioneering engineer **Steve Wozniak**.



Rei Kawakubo, founder and lead designer at the fashion brand Comme des Garçons, and her husband **Adrian Joffe**, the company's president and spokesperson.



Entrepreneur **John O. Morisano** and executive chef **Mashama Bailey** of the award-winning restaurant The Grey.





“You can have the world’s best strategy for growing your business, but if your culture isn’t right, it’s not gonna go where you want it to go.”

— SARA BLAKELY

The Power of Communication

On the challenges (and importance) of navigating team dynamics effectively

As a leader, you need to model empathy and understanding, but the result may come off as superficial if you forget the importance of listening.

Put simply, communicating effectively is a two-way street. It's critical for you to narrow the gulf between the way you deliver information and how you receive it. (Leaders who listen well also receive higher ratings than poor listeners, according to the U.S. business publication *Forbes*.)

Take it from Mike "Coach K" Krzyzewski, who holds the all-time record for wins by an NCAA men's college basketball coach. He uses the term *making reads*—or reading situations and reading people. Doing so means you can adjust your decisions based on what's happening in the moment.

"You're adapting by listening, by asking for input, knowing the goal, and knowing the time frame that you have," he says.

So, how can you apply all of this directly? Think about your recent team interactions. What was your biggest obstacle to getting honest feedback from your team? What are some ways you might improve how you gather feedback?

EXERCISE: ASK YOURSELF THIS

Before chiming in during your next group conversation or meeting, step back and ask: *Why am I talking? Does what I'm saying affirm that I've been paying attention to (and understanding) others? Or is there a subconscious urge to turn the attention back on myself?* This is a particularly helpful strategy for those in positions of formal authority (managers, project leads, etc.); in such a power dynamic, your words can quickly overwhelm a discussion and make people shut down. Use this opportunity to make room for others: They might just make the point you were going to make.

WORK SMARTER

To apply what you've learned, consider the following scenarios and work through the thought exercises at the end:

Having difficult conversations

The lesson: As a leader, sometimes you have to be the bearer of bad news. You need to be forthright but also empathetic.

The situation: You had to make a tough decision that is going to create some frustration for members of your team.

The exercise: How do you communicate the decision to your team?

Celebrating and giving credit

The lesson: As a leader, you also get to share the good news. You want to celebrate these moments to motivate and engage your team.

The situation: Performance numbers just came in and your team knocked it out of the park.

The exercise: How do you communicate the success to your team?

TRY THIS

For the next eight weeks, select one item from this checklist every Monday morning. During the week, focus on practicing your skills as they relate to that area:

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Leading by example | ☐ Celebrating team wins |
| ☐ Recognizing your weaknesses (and delegating accordingly) | ☐ Nurturing personal and professional growth in others |
| ☐ Empowering others through listening | ☐ Owning your mistakes and giving credit when and where it's due |
| ☐ Communicating with clarity | ☐ Making it fun! |

